

PET FRIENDS A silent protest in Mumbai against a Bombay High Court order that penalises Nagpur's stray dog feeders

- **DO NOT POKE AND PROD A DOG'S BODY PARTS,** especially the tail, when the dog comes up to you for petting
- **IF YOU ARE UNCOMFORTABLE WITH AN AFFECTIONATE DOG,** instead of pushing it away or threatening it, just continue walking. They will not follow you outside of their territory
- **IF YOU ARE STILL AFRAID,** ask the society guards or local feeders for help in passing through the dog's territory. There is usually somebody in the area the dogs will trust and are familiar with

to ensure there is no population explosion," says Satyanarayan.

A POPULATION EXPLOSION?

In 2021, the State of Pet Homelessness Index data for India estimated the country has around 62 million stray dogs, with 77 per cent saying they see a stray dog at least once a week. This is a dog-to-human ratio of nearly five dogs for 100 people, which is still above the World Organization for Animal Health-recommended three dogs for 100 people. Figures tabled in the Lok Sabha this year were more conservative, pegging the number of homeless dogs in the country at 17.1 million. They also noted an all-India decline of 10 per cent from 2012 to 2019. The decrease was the sharpest in Uttar Pradesh where numbers reduced by half from 4.2 million in 2012 to 2.1 million in 2019. The highest rise was in Karnataka, followed by Rajasthan. In the livestock census in 2019, Manipur and Dadra & Nagar Haveli were declared stray dog-free. "Dogs don't live for very long on the streets—about six years on average—because it is the survival of the fittest and older dogs get pushed out or don't get enough food. Pups, too, rarely make it to adulthood, with only one or two in every litter surviving. So, it is a mistaken belief that we are facing a street dog population explosion," says Satyanarayan.

Experts say it is important that states where the sterilisation programme isn't yielding enough results step up their efforts for better population control. These include Odisha, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Haryana, Kerala and the Union territory of Jammu and Kashmir, where numbers rose between 2012 and 2019, according to the same Lok Sabha report. "Wherever animal birth control rules are implemented, you won't have issues of stray dogs attacking humans. There has to be a consistent sterilisation programme that breaks the whole pack code behaviour," says Aras. The Animal Welfare Board of India, the central government's apex body on animal welfare, has written to all states asking them to comply with rules by having an active sterilisation programme in place. "When dogs are unsterilised, fights between them may occur, and rarely, a human may get caught in the middle. An effective sterilisation programme helps prevent such situations. Since territories are not left vacant, new dogs cannot enter. Over time, as the dogs die natural deaths, their numbers dwindle. The dog population becomes stable, non-breeding, non-aggressive and rabies-free, and it gradually decreases over time," says Meet Ashar, manager of cruelty response projects, PETA India. Sterilisation also helps dismantle the alpha dog mentality of a pack as hormones that drive males to compete over a female or territory are no longer present. "Sterilised, vaccinated, and well-fed and cared-for community dogs also prevent unsterilised, unvaccinated and unfamiliar dogs from entering their territory. This stabilises the community dog population of the neighbourhood," adds Ashar.

But sterilising street dogs is not always an easy task. Catching them remains a challenge for many municipalities as dogs run away or attack strangers. "Sometimes, it is dog lovers who resist the animals being taken for neutering. They want to know where the dog is being taken and when it would be back. More awareness is needed to tell people that it's best for the future of stray dogs that they are neutered," says Dr Umesh Bhaskar, a veterinarian with Navodaya, the agency neutering dogs in Bhopal municipal limits. The Animal Birth Control (Dogs) Rules, 2001, state that after neutering, the dogs must be released in the same place from where they were taken. But some municipalities have faced threats from societies when it was time to return the dogs. "We have to fight to collect the dogs and sometimes we have to fight to release them because not everyone wants them back. The country is divided over street dogs and this love-hate divide often gets in the way of our work," says a Delhi municipality member.

In some cities, civic bodies have realised that working with feeders leads to better results. Mumbai is one such example where feeders help capture the dogs and ensure that all dogs under their care are vaccinated and sterilised. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), in turn, has set aside Rs 4 crore for its sterilisation budget in 2022-2023 and feeders say the process has always been smooth. "Everyone sees stray dogs as a nuisance and wants them to be taken away from their premises. Coexistence is important; dogs are a part of our ecosystem. The population of stray dogs needs to be brought to a figure that is well accepted by the human population of the region, to pre-empt any conflict. If stray dogs live in healthy and sanitary conditions and don't suffer from ailments and illnesses, the conflict and problems are reduced," says Dr Kalimpasha Pathan, general manager at the BMC's veterinary health department. As of September this year, the municipal body has sterilised 386,347 dogs and